7. From Shelters to Village-settlements

7.1 Shelter

7.2 Seasonal camps

7.3 Village-settlements

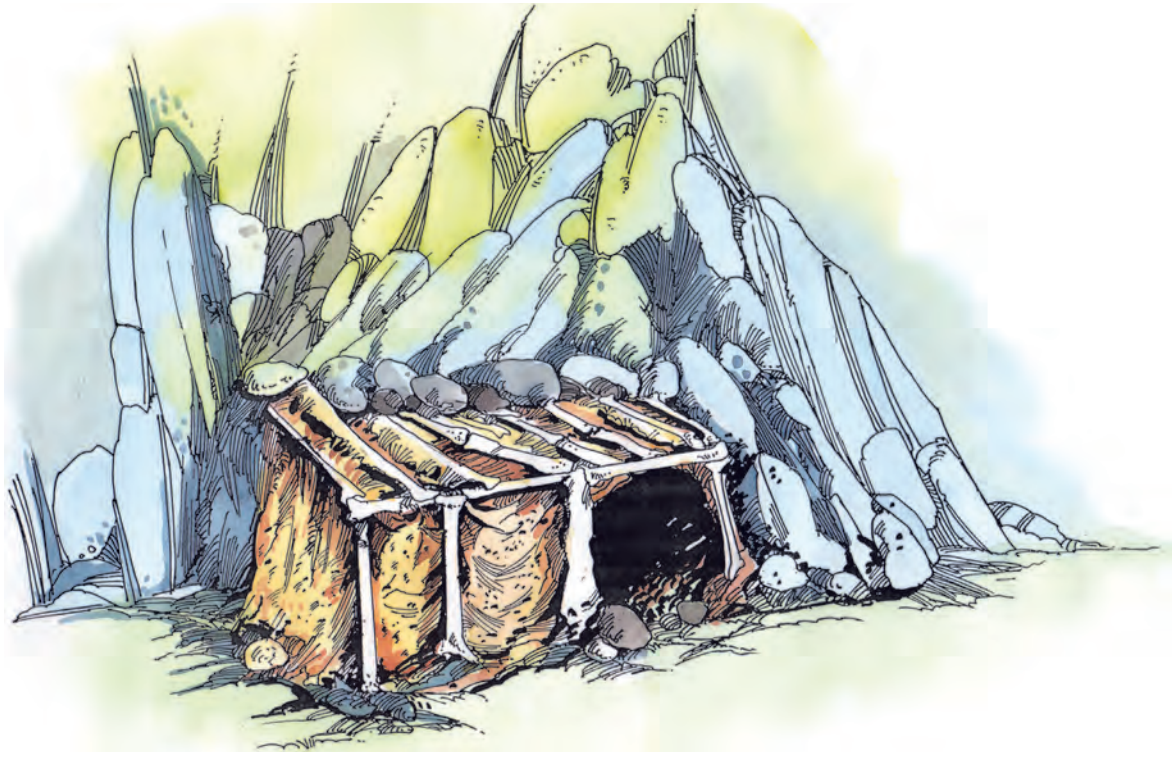
7.1 Shelter

In the fifth lesson, we saw that the Neanderthals lived mainly in caves. At that time, the climate in Europe was extremely cold. The Neanderthals could protect themselves from the freezing temperatures because they wore leather clothing and made use of fire. Perhaps, that was not enough. That is why they used animal hides to erect tents inside the caves for warmth. Wherever necessary, they also built huts in the open.

7.2 Seasonal camps

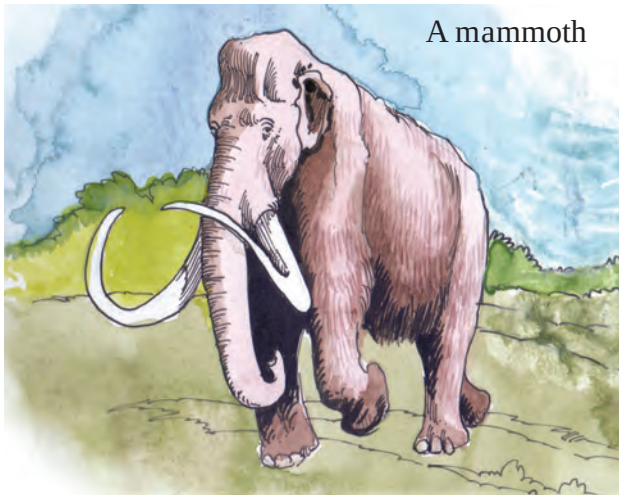
In the Middle Stone Age, groups of *Homo sapiens* had established camps all over the world. At that time, the climate was getting warmer. Everywhere the environment was changing. And with it, the diet of *Homo sapiens* was also undergoing change.

By the time of the Middle Stone Age, big animals like mammoths were on the way to extinction due to the changing environment and also because they were hunted on a very large scale. That is why, *Homo sapiens* had largely turned to fishing. He also began to depend more

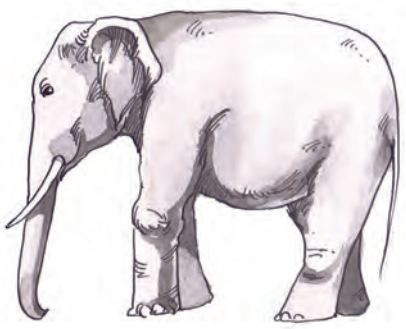


A warm two-room tent erected by Neanderthal Man inside a cave - France

The mammoth was an ancestor of the elephant. However, he was much bigger in size compared to the elephant.



A mammoth



An elephant

on hunting smaller animals like the wild boar, deer, mountain goat and sheep.

The changed diet pattern enabled the groups of *Homo sapiens* to roam to faraway regions. They moved their camps to different places according to seasonal changes. There they harvested seasonal wild grains and gathered seasonal fruits and roots. They would find out the best seasons for fishing and use the knowledge to their advantage. By observation, they discovered the best hunting grounds. For these reasons, they stayed in one



A reconstruction of a seasonal camp – Middle Stone Age



A reconstruction of a village-settlement – New Stone Age

place for longer periods. They cleared jungles by felling trees and set up their seasonal camps in the clearings.

7.3 Village-settlements

The way of life of humans in the New Stone Age was completely different from that of humans in the Old Stone Age and Middle Stone Age. During this period, humans became producers of foodgrains. The beginning of cultivation is a characteristic of the culture of the New Stone Age. In the hunting and gathering way of life, it is necessary to keep moving all the time. However, agriculture makes it possible to store food and use it over a longer period. Hence, there is no need to keep moving constantly. Moreover, the nature of agricultural work made it necessary to stay in one place. Therefore, people established permanent village-settlements and lived in them generation after generation. In the next lesson, we shall review the social organization and the culture of these village-settlements.

Exercises

1. Answer each of the following questions in one sentence.

(a) Which animals did the *Homo sapiens* mainly hunt?

(b) What is the characteristic of the New Stone Age?

2. Give reasons for the following.

(a) The diet of *Homo sapiens* underwent a change.

(b) *Homo sapiens* needed to stay in one place over longer periods of time.

3. Observe the reconstructed picture of a Middle Stone Age seasonal camp and answer the following.

(a) Describe the structure of the houses in the picture.

(b) What materials are used to construct the houses?

(c) What kind of jobs could the people in the seasonal camps have been doing?

4. Write about the effects on your life, of the seasonal changes in weather.

5. Compare the New Stone Age village with a modern village.

Activities

(a) Construct models of different types of houses.

(b) Visit agricultural farms and collect information of the various agricultural tasks that farmers have to do.

(c) Visit five different types of houses in your locality and collect information about the materials used in the construction of those houses.

(d) With your teacher's help, observe the continents shown on a world map or a globe and write short notes about them.



Do you know this?

The earth is subject to cycles of glacial and interglacial periods. In the glacial period, most of the earth's surface is covered with ice sheets and the climate is extremely cold and dry. The level of water in the sea falls because a lot of it is converted into ice. An interglacial period is the period between two glacial periods. During the interglacial period, a large part of the ice on the ground melts. Sea levels rise. The climate becomes warmer and more humid. When some regions in the world experienced a glacial, Asia and Africa experienced heavy rainfall. On the other hand, when some regions experienced an interglacial, Asia and Africa experienced poor rainfall.

About 25 lakh years ago, that is, in the times of *Homo habilis*, the climate had started becoming extremely cold and dry. During the period from 18 lakh years to 11 thousand years ago, there have been four major cycles of glacial and interglacial periods. This is also the period when the history of human culture from Old Stone Age to Middle Stone Age took shape. About 11,000 years ago, the last glacial period came to an end and the current interglacial began. The climate started to become warmer and more humid again. Agriculture and the New Stone Age also began at about the same time.

❑❑❑